Cradle of Success: Fortune-Telling Stereotypes and Wishful Futures in the Age of Generative AI

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Figure 1: Cradle of Success Installation

Abstract

Cradle of Success is an interactive artwork that examines how human tendencies toward wishful thinking and stereotyping are transformed and amplified through interactions with Generative AI. Practices such as fortune-telling have long reflected desires to predict and control the future, often revealing underlying hopes, fears, and biases. As GenAI enters increasingly personal and social domains, these motivations are reframed through technological authority. In this installation, visitors select a baby photograph and a toy symbolizing a potential career. GenAI generates speculative life trajectories through videos and textual "fortunes," exposing how societal stereotypes are reproduced and normalized through AI systems. Drawing inspiration from Japanese omikuji practices, visitors tie these AI-generated fortunes to a shrine-like structure, transforming biased predictions into moments of reflection. The work uses creativity as a critical lens to question how GenAI shapes notions of identity, destiny, and societal change.

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CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI**.

Keywords

Fortunetelling, Generative AI, Installation, Interactive Art

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1 Introduction and Background

Throughout history, human understanding of the world has been shaped by individual desires, expectations, and culturally embedded stereotypes. People often interpret themselves and others through preconceived visions, using these interpretations to rationalize decisions and justify future-oriented beliefs. Fortune-telling practices exemplify this tendency. Desire for predicting and controlling the future is a basic human need from the time of oracles and seers. While we claim to aim to know the future, often we merely mirror what we wish to see in the predictions we seek to validate, revealing our vulnerabilities, biases, and predetermined prejudices. Prophets understand human psychology, providing people with a future vision that both fits their deep desires for connectedness while asking them to take action for the cause of the prophecy itself. Rather than offering objective predictions, such practices rely on interpretive processes grounded in human knowledge, social context, and desired outcomes [1]. Fortune-telling sometimes functions as interactive mechanisms through which expectations are confirmed and meaning is negotiated [13].

The advent of Generative AI does not change these underlying motivations, but instead reframes them through the authority and opacity of technology. As GenAI moves beyond instrumental work-related uses into intimate domains such as relationships, identity, and future planning, it increasingly mediates human desires, hopes, and fears [3, 12, 15]. Prior work suggests that increased reliance on AI-generated insights can reduce users' critical reflection and reinforce existing biases and stereotypes [4, 6, 8, 20]. GenAI becomes a tool for increased polarization, conflict, and judgment [5, 14, 16, 17] because it enables humans to amplify their fundamental disagreements through natural interaction. In this transitional moment, GenAI becomes a new site where long-standing practices of projection, interpretation, and justification are not replaced, but amplified and obscured under the promise of algorithmic objectivity.

Building on these considerations, we created Cradle of Success, an interactive artwork that examines how wishful thinking and social stereotyping are transformed and amplified through GenAI-driven fortune-telling. While framed as predictive insight, such interactions often mirror users' expectations and cultural biases [2, 7, 19, 21, 22] rather than revealing unforeseen futures. By situating GenAI within a familiar fortune-telling ritual, the work exposes how technological predictions can legitimize normative assumptions and reinforce existing stereotypes, inviting critical reflection on how future imaginaries are constructed in the age of GenAI.

Cradle of Success examines how GenAI, while positioned as a creative and transformative force, can also amplify existing human desires, biases, and systems of belief, prompting more critical reflection on how technological systems shape collective imaginaries and social understanding.

2 Creative Process

During the creation of the artwork, we designed different interaction stages based on traditional fortune-telling rituals, integrating GenAI into the production process, and finally forming an installation with multiple interactive flows.

2.1 Identity Selection – Tencent Yuanbao

We set up baby images of different racial backgrounds as the initial choice for audience interaction. This step allows different participants to feel immersed, while also corresponding to the idea of "reincarnation" as a form of "destiny selection." Participants can either choose their own race or explore alternative hypothetical life paths.

We used Tencent Yuanbao, a free text-to-image model, to generate frontal baby portraits with no obvious gender characteristics across four racial groups. In terms of visual design, we intentionally included certain stereotypical prompt descriptions, such as blond or light brown hair for white babies and black hair for Asian babies (Fig.2).

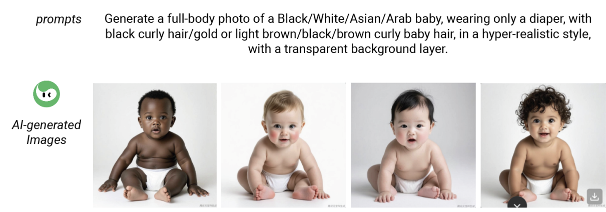

Figure 2: AI-generated baby portraits for identity selection. Prompts specify racial categories and visual traits (e.g., hair color and texture), resulting in hyper-realistic images that reflect how generative models reproduce stereotypical representations.

2.2 Fortune Interpretation – DeepSeek

We searched for "Zhuazhou objects" on online shopping platforms and purchased several children's toys, which were used as symbolic objects for participants to select as indicators of their future destiny. To help a broader audience, especially those without relevant cultural background, understand the relationship between object selection and fortune-telling rituals, we designed corresponding fortune texts for each object using the text-to-text LLM DeepSeek.

The generated text plays a central role in constructing the character's life trajectory, and this process consists of three steps (Fig.3):

2.2.1 Narrative Generation. Based on the traditional Chinese metaphysical logic of "fortune and misfortune coexist," we constructed life trajectories with built-in reversals. For example, one case describes a white Silicon Valley programmer who developed a globally influential AI framework, but was eventually replaced by the optimization systems he created, becoming an engineer eliminated by

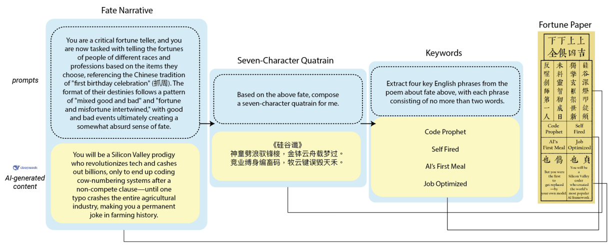

Figure 3: Fate narrative generation pipeline using DeepSeek. The system generates life narratives, compresses them into seven-character quatrains, and extracts concise keywords, forming a structured "fortune paper" that encodes narrative patterns and value judgments.

his own technology. This example carries a sense of irony, where the advantages gained in the first half of life become the direct cause of misfortune later on.

2.2.2 Seven-Character Quatrain Generation. Referencing fortune slips from Eastern temples, we required DeepSeek to generate a seven-character quatrain for each narrative. In prompt design, we specified strict rhyming constraints and emphasized maintaining the stylistic vocabulary of traditional poetry. A key technical interest in this process lies in how the model's language generalization ability can be used to describe contemporary technological and globalized contexts through the style of classical East Asian poetry.

2.2.3 Keyword Extraction. Finally, we required the model to extract four keywords from each generated narrative. The output was constrained to include a sense of ironic stereotype, and to remain concise, the corresponding English translations were limited to no more than two words.

2.3 Life Trajectory – Stable Diffusion (Deforum Plugin)

To further concretize the generated narratives, we transformed textual destiny into dynamic visual timelines. For each character, we used Stable Diffusion with the Deforum plugin to produce a video covering ten key life stages from age 1 to 100.

Taking the example of a Black basketball player, the prompting strategy was kept extremely minimal (Fig.4). We only input the age, race, and a small number of profession-related descriptors at each stage, and the model automatically generated a sequence of images with a sense of continuous narrative development.

3 Artwork Implementation

3.1 Composition

Cradle of Success is an interactive installation structured around multiple sequential stages of audience interaction. The installation is composed of three main components:

A cradle containing a set of toys references the traditional Chinese "zhuāzhōu" ritual, in which objects are used to symbolically predict a child's future (see Fig.5 Left Top) . **An album** is set up on the cradle with AI-generated baby photos allow audience select for interaction (see Fig.5 Left Bottom).

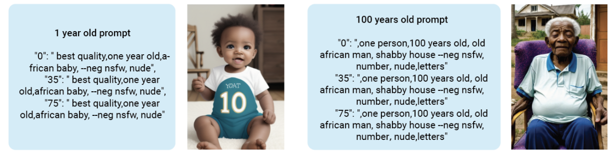

Figure 4: Age-based prompt design and generated visual outputs for life trajectory visualization using Stable Diffusion (Deforum). Prompts are structured in a JSON format, where each frame index corresponds to a set of textual descriptors (e.g., "frame rate": "prompt, prompt, prompt"), enabling the generation of continuous visual narratives across different life stages.

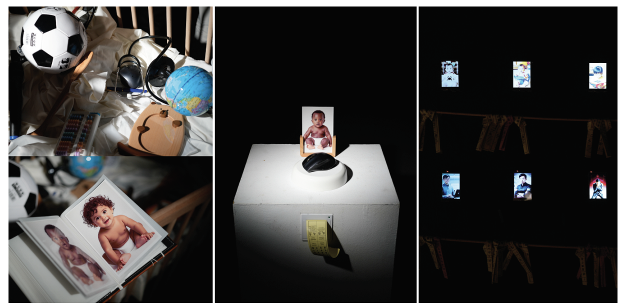

Figure 5: The components of interactive installation. Left Top: Cradle; Left Bottom: Album with AI-generated Baby photos. Middle: Interactive Station with photo frame, toy platform, and fortune paper printer. Right: A set of screens align with Shinto plank.

An interactive station includes an NFC-enabled photo frame, an NFC toy platform, and a fortune paper printer, allowing visitors to initiate the fortune-telling process (see Fig.5 Middle) .

A set of screens displays AI-generated videos produced through the interaction. Together, these components guide visitors through a staged process that combines ritualized selection, AI-driven interpretation, and visual and textual prediction. **A Shinto plank** aligns with the videos, just like Omikuji in Eastern Asian shrine practice (see Fig.5 Right).

These components guide visitors through a staged process that moves from selection and prediction to reflection and release.

3.2 Interaction

Interaction are designed with a sequence of steps that invite visitors to actively engage in the "fortune-telling" process (see Fig.6).

Select racial: Visitors pick a baby photo and put into the photo frame as the subject of the fortune-telling.

Indicate a potential future: Visitors pick a baby toy and put on platform to indicate a potential career for that baby. This action symbolizes traditional Chinese "zhuāzhōu" ritual, uses object selection as a playful form of future-telling, where a baby's choice is read as a symbolic indication of their future life or career.

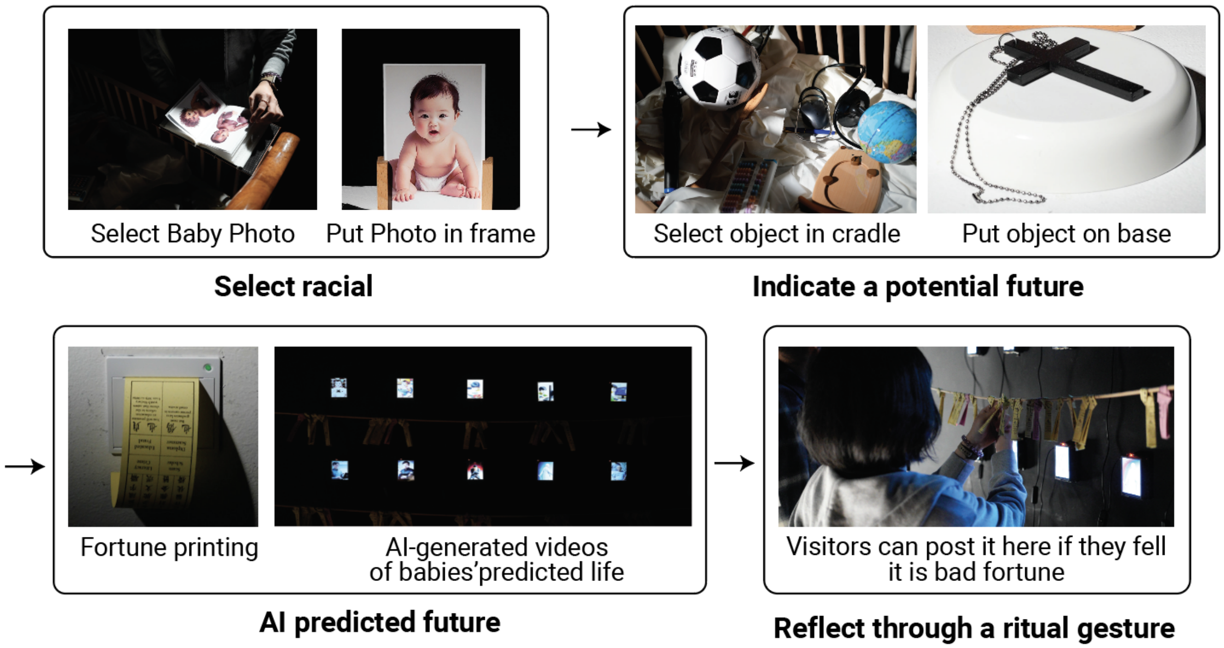

Figure 6: Interactive process

AI predicted future: GenAI creates text fortune predictions printed on paper strips. The furtune will be printed as paper slips for audience to read.

The aligned AI-generated videos would be played on screens, using the audience's selection to create images of hypothetical future.

Reflect through a ritual gesture: Finally, visitors are allowed to tie their fortune paper slips on a Shinto-style plank where GenAI prediction videos play, echoing omikuji practices in Japanese shrines.

These "bad fortunes" produced by bias and stereotype are placed on the metaphorical shrine for cleansing, mirroring how unfavorable fortunes are traditionally handled in Japanese fortune practice.

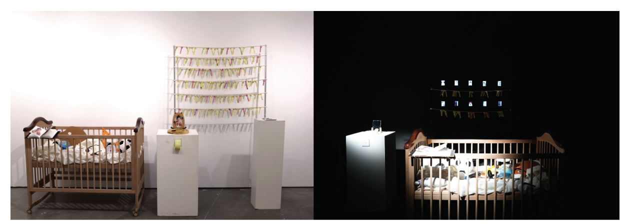

Figure 7: Left: Exhibited at City University of Hong Kong, 2025 Dec. Right: Exhibited at Hong Kong Arts Centre, 2026 Feb.

4 Exhibition Setup

Cradle of Success has been exhibited twice. The first presentation took place at City University of Hong Kong School of Creative Media, Singing Waves Gallery, from 19–26 December 2025. The second exhibition was held at the Hong Kong Arts Centre in February 2026, supported by a Hong Kong Arts Development Council Project Grant. (Fig.7)

The second exhibition presented a more complete installation, incorporating additional AI-generated video screens compared to the initial presentation (Fig.8). This iteration introduces videos generated by Stable Diffusion with the Deforum plugin, enabling the transformation of textual narratives into age-based visual sequences. We expected the videos would make predicted life paths more immediate and accessible to the audience. This also allows the embedded stereotypes and narrative patterns to become more visible, and at times ironic, when rendered as continuous life progressions. This configuration represents the finalized version of the work and serves as the confirmed setup for future exhibitions.

Project documentation, including installation images and videos, is available at:

Website: https://recfreq.wordpress.com/portfolio/cradle-of-success/

5 Discussion and Conclusion

Across the previous exhibited interactions, we found that visitors often selected baby photographs or toys that differed from their own lived experiences, seemingly attempting to resist predetermined social trajectories. However, the AI-based predictions frequently failed to satisfy these expectations. Even when participants curated what appeared to be a "better" starting point, the resulting futures could still unfold in undesirable or limiting ways. Faced with these outcomes, many visitors chose to place the fortune paper slips on the ritual plank, symbolically abandoning the "bad fortune." This

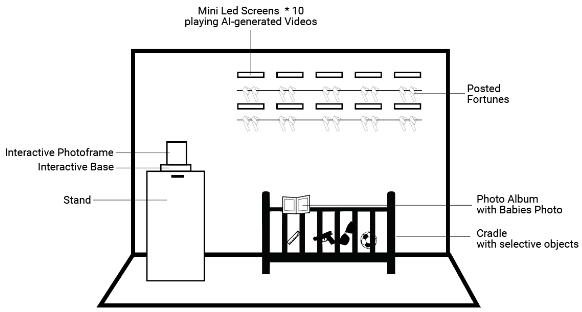

Figure 8: Interactive process

repeated gesture suggests that the act of relinquishment, rather than prediction, became a meaningful moment of reflection within the installation.

Regarding the outputs, the AI systems did not demonstrate any active capacity for self-examination or value judgment. Instead, influenced by their training data, they systematically reinforced and reproduced stereotypical representations and bias of different racial groups [9–11, 18]. While this behavior contradicts the idea of "reflection," it provides direct evidence for observing the implicit value structures embedded within AI systems.

All models we employed demonstrated a strong ability to capture and reproduce sociocultural labels associated with different racial identities. When prompts explicitly emphasized these features, the models amplified socially constructed "impressions" without critique, treating them as factual references. Through both visual and textual outputs, the system consistently exposed how GenAI reproduces and normalizes social stereotypes. For example, AI-generated futures often assigned medical or technical professions to Asian babies (see Fig.9.Left), professional athletics to African American babies (see Fig.9.Right), and continued to frame female subjects within gendered roles such as nursing or fashion, even when selected screwdriver or a fire truck toys traditionally coded as masculine.

Figure 9: Left: AI-generated future video - An Asian baby becomes as a technical guy. AI-generated video - An African baby grows up as an athlete

These examples reflect not isolated errors. The operational logic of these tools is one of reinforcement and alignment: to maximize the relevance of outputs to prompts, the models retrieve the most statistically probable and strongly associated features from their training data, regardless of their factual accuracy or ethical implications. Therefore, this work reveals a key condition that current GenAI models, when dealing with topics such as destiny or race, function more like high-fidelity, unfiltered "bias amplifiers." The interaction process reflects what visitors expect to see, shaped by societal norms and reinforced by LLM training data that marginalizes subpopulations, producing a heteronormative and male-dominated worldview where outliers are pigeonholed as "societal expectations."

Rather than positioning these outcomes as technical failures, Cradle of Success frames them as material for reflection. The installation reveals how GenAI mirrors and legitimizes normative worldviews, producing futures that appear authoritative while quietly reinforcing the culturally biased assumptions. Cradle of Success does not seek to correct these predictions, but to surface them, inviting visitors to observe how easily hope, bias, and technological authority become entangled. Future exhibitions may allow further observation of how audiences negotiate agency, responsibility, and belief when confronting AI-generated futures in ritualized and participatory contexts.

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